CAREER GLITCH · SHORT · SIMPLE · NO BORING PARTS

ROOFER IN THE AI ERA

Every roof is a countdown timer, and storms reset thousands of them at once. This is the trades' rawest work — and its most weather-powered demand.

★ TL;DR — Median around $45K, enterable in 1–6 months with no license required for the work itself. The catch: heights, heat and the hardest physical ledger in construction — roofer pay stays modest until you run crews or sell jobs. ★

THE CAREER GLITCH TAKE

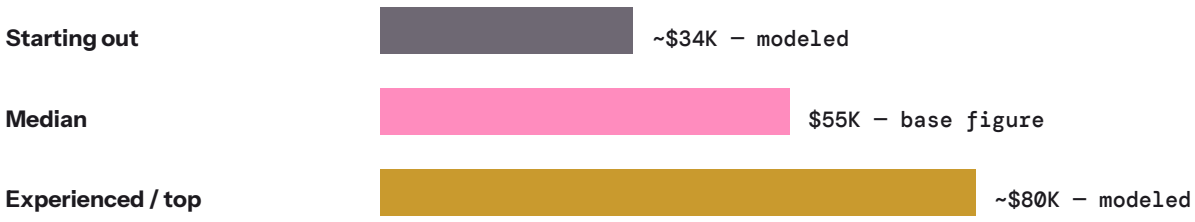
OUR TAKE: YES

MEDIAN ~$55K · TRAINING 1-6 months · AI RISK LOW

- Works because: roofs wear out on schedule and fail dramatically in storms; replacement is never optional for a building.
- Bites because: it's brutal on bodies, seasonal in cold climates, and production pay for crew hands is capped.
- AI angle: minimal on the roof. Drones inspect and software measures, but tear-off, decking and installation are human hands at height.

The site's take, built from this profession's numbers in the Career Glitch base.

THE MONEY — LOOK AT THE BARS



The Career Glitch base figure for Roofer is a ~$55K median (compiled from U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics, Occupational Outlook Handbook ranges). The starting and top bars are modeled around that median — orientation, not a promise. Pay swings hard by state, employer and experience: check live postings in your state before planning around any number.

WHAT DOES A ROOFER ACTUALLY DO?

- ✓ Tear off old roofing down to the deck and inspect/repair the decking itself
- ✓ Install underlayment, flashing, shingles or other systems — straight, sealed and ventilated right
- ✓ Haul materials up and debris down, all day, in whatever the sky is doing
- ✓ Run leak repairs: find where water actually enters, which is rarely where it drips

Think: a mountain crew that builds the summit as it goes — exposure, teamwork, and zero tolerance for a careless step.

WHAT AI ALREADY TOOK (AND WHAT IT CAN'T)

THE ROBOT	THE HUMAN
Drone inspections, satellite measurements and estimating software changed the office side completely. The roof itself still belongs to crews with nail guns and harnesses.	Leak diagnosis (water lies about where it came from), flashing craftsmanship at valleys and chimneys, and safety judgment in wind and heat. Experience reads a roof like a story.

⚠ **Falls are the leading killer in construction and roofing leads the category. Any company casual about harnesses and anchors is telling you how it values you — leave. The money upgrade in roofing is supervision and sales, not stronger knees.**

THE VIBE — IS THIS YOUR LIFE?

THE JOB IS	THE JOB IS NOT
✓ Outdoors, moving, with a crew — no walls, no screens ✓ Storm seasons bring intense, well-paid work surges ✓ Visible daily progress: a house is weather-tight because of you	✗ Heights, heat on black shingles, cold wind in winter ✗ Heavy bundles, steep pitches, punishing pace ✗ Weather calls the schedule — rain days can mean no pay

Good fit? You're strong, sure-footed, not afraid of heights, and you respect safety systems instead of mocking them.
Bad fit? You fear heights, have balance or heat issues, or want a long gentle career for your joints. Pick a trade that happens indoors.

THE FORK — PICK ONE DOOR

DOOR A — ROOFING CREW HAND	DOOR B — ROOFING SALES / INSPECTION

Roofing companies hire crew hands constantly, storm regions especially. You'll start on tear-off and ground work, move up to installation, and learn systems (shingle, metal, flat) as you go — 1–6 months tells you if your body and head accept the trade.	Storm-restoration companies hire inspectors and sales reps to assess damage, document claims and sell replacements — commission-based, far less physical, and a real career lane for people who like roofs more than carrying them.

Smart move: Learn flashing and leak repair deeply, and one premium system (metal or flat roofing). Every crew can shingle; the person who finds the leak and flashes a chimney right is the one foremen fight over.

Where you land after: Crew hand → installer → foreman → project manager or roofing company owner; or inspector → sales → sales management.

YOUR ROADMAP — 6 STEPS

1	2	3	4	5	6
GET ON	SURVIVE TEAR-OFF,	INSTALL TO	ADD A	LEARN LEAK	RUN CREWS

STEP 1 — Get on a crew safely

FREE · WEEK 1

- Apply to roofing companies; ask directly about their fall-protection practices in the interview.
- Boots with grip and a harness you trust are not optional gear.

STEP 2 — Survive tear-off, learn the deck

MONTHS 1-3

- Tear-off teaches what roofs die of: rot, bad flashing, skipped underlayment.
- Learn decking repair and ventilation basics while the old roof is open.

STEP 3 — Install to standard

MONTHS 2-6

- Nailing patterns, courses, valleys, ridges — speed follows correctness, never the reverse.
- Master flashing details; that's the craftsmanship gap between crews.

STEP 4 — Add a premium system

ONGOING

- Metal, TPO/flat, or tile roofing — specialization raises day rates and steadies work.
- Manufacturer install certifications back your name with their warranty programs.

STEP 5 — Learn leak calls

MONTHS 4+

- Ride along on repair calls: diagnosis is the highest-paid thinking on a roof.
- Keep a leak journal — water's favorite tricks repeat.

STEP 6 — Run crews or jobs YEAR 1+

- Foreman route: lead installs, own quality and safety on site.
- Business route: contractor licensing/registration where required, insurance, and your first sales pipeline.

FIRST 90 DAYS — JUST DO THIS

- □ Today: apply to three roofing companies; ask each about fall protection.
- □ Days 1–30: tear-off and ground work; learn what failed roofs die of.
- □ Days 31–60: installation reps — courses, nailing patterns, ridge work.
- □ Days 61–90: flashing details under the foreman; first leak-call ride-alongs.
- □ Day 90: a working roofer with safe habits and a specialty picked — supervision or systems, that's the fork.

NEXT — MAKE IT PERSONAL

This roadmap is the same for everyone. Your life is not.

- Not sure this career fits YOU? Take the Big Career Test — 50 questions, your top-3 matches and one honest "probably NOT you". → careerglitch.com/#test
- Already sure? Turn AI into Your Personal Career Mentor — a 2,300-word system that interviews you first, checks your hours, budget and deadline honestly, and builds YOUR plan into a Notion dashboard. → careerglitch.com/#prompt

★ **RESPECT THE HEIGHT. MASTER THE FLASHING.** ★

CAREER GLITCH · Figures: Career Glitch profession base (medians and training ranges compiled from U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics, Occupational Outlook Handbook ranges). Modeled bars are estimates around the base median. License and certification rules vary by state — verify with your state board before paying for any program.